

Lecture Printout, Week 04: Act-Utilitarianism / Consequentialism

PART I: CONSEQUENTIALISM CHARACTERIZED.

- Q1: The rightness of an act-token depends upon what? : _____
- Q2: What *kind* of state of the world? _____
- Q3: What *makes* a state of the world count as good? _____
- Q4: Do any answers stand out as popular? _____
- Q5: *Whose* well-being counts towards the rightness of act-tokens?
 Ethical egoists say: _____
 Partialists say: _____
 Impartialists say: _____
- Q6: And what does **well-being consist in**, anyway?

PART II: EARLY STATEMENTS OF CONSEQUENTIALIST THEORIES.

- Mòzǐ (400s – 300s BCE):** [1] “The business of the benevolent man must be to seek assiduously to promote the world’s benefits and^[SEP] to eliminate the world’s harms” (*The Mozi*, §6.1). [2] “[I]f the world is poor,[the benevolent person] works to make it rich. If the people [of the world] are few, He works to make them numerous. If they are numerous but in disorder, he works to bring them order” (*ibid.* §25.1).
- Jeremy Bentham (1748 – 1832):** [1] “An action then may be said to be conformable to the principle of utility... when the tendency it has to augment the happiness of the community^[SEP] is greater than any it has to diminish it” (Bentham, *Principles of Morals and Legislation*, p.3). [2] “The only right and justifiable end of Government [is] the greatest happiness of the greatest number” (*ibid.* p.5n1).
- John Stuart Mill (1806 – 1873):** [1] “[A]ctions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness; wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness. By happiness is intended pleasure and the absence of pain; by unhappiness, pain and the privation of pleasure” (Mill, *Utilitarianism*, p. 210) [2] “[The utilitarian] standard is not the agent’s own greatest happiness, but the greatest amount of happiness altogether (*ibid.* p. 213)

PART III: THE CONTEMPORARY FORMULATION OF ACT-UTILITARIANISM.

- D1. ‘Act-token x is **an alternative** to act-token y’ =df. the agent of y could perform x instead of y, but cannot perform x in addition **to** y.
- D2. The hedonic utility of act-token x’ =df. ‘The total quantity of pain there would be in the world, if x was performed, subtracted from the total quantity of pleasure there would be in the world, if x was performed.’
- D3. ‘Act-token x maximizes hedonic utility’ =df. ‘x results in at least as much hedonic utility as any alternative to x.’
- D3’. ‘Act-token x maximizes hedonic utility’ =df ‘no alternative to x results in a greater amount of hedonic utility than x’.
- AUh: An act-token, x, is **morally right** if and only if x maximizes hedonic utility.

PART IV: AUH ILLUSTRATED BY AN EXAMPLE.

Letter to an advice column: “My husband and I have been friends with another couple for many years.[...] Recently a mutual acquaintance who knows my friend’s husband well told me that he has been cheating on my friend on and off for years with someone who once worked with him. I know that if I reveal this information, my friend will take their child and leave her husband. Do I sit on this information and pretend the affair isn’t happening, or do I tell her?” -Name Withheld. (New York Times Magazine, 31 Dec. 2019)
Source: <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/12/31/magazine/should-i-tell-my-friend-her-husband-is-cheating-on-her.html>

Act-token 1: Stay Quiet.

Act-token 2: Tell Friend.

PART V: CLARIFICATORY QUESTIONS ABOUT AUH.

Q1: If my act causes some pleasure and no pain, does that make it right, according to AUh?

Q2: What does AUh imply about an act that causes some pain in addition to pleasure?

Q3: What if I have to choose between two actions where **both** produce a net positive utility?

Q4: What if my only available actions all produce a **net negative** of utility?^[SEP]

Q5: One more question: what if two alternative actions are **tied for highest net utility**?

PART VI: THEORETICAL ADVANTAGES OF AUH.

Some reasons some philosophers sometimes find AUh to be a plausible theory of right action, compared with some of its rivals.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____